What It Means to Be Human · Part Two of Four

The Wound at the Root

Sin and the Fractured Self

The Kiln Ministries / Great Physician Application

Sources: Holy Scripture; Calvin, *Institutes*; Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics* Vol. 3 / CW / PoR; Watson, Boston, Owen, Sibbes

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Preface: Why the Fall Matters

Part One of this series established the extraordinary dignity of the human person as the image-bearer of God — crowned with glory, endowed with original righteousness, oriented toward God as his proper end and rest. But dignity alone does not explain the human condition as it actually presents itself. The person who sits across from a counselor is not simply a glorious image-bearer in need of encouragement. He is a broken, confused, guilty, and often deeply self-deceived creature who has sinned against God, against others, and against himself — and who, in many cases, does not fully understand the nature or depth of his own condition.

The doctrine of the image tells us what man was made to be. The doctrine of the fall tells us what happened to it. It is impossible to care well for a human soul without an honest reckoning with what sin has done to the person who bears it. Thomas Boston structures his account of *Human Nature in Its Fourfold State* by moving through innocence, corruption, grace, and glory in deliberate sequence — because each state is only intelligible in light of what preceded it. You cannot understand the grace without the corruption. And you cannot understand what a person needs without understanding, honestly and without sentimentality, the nature and extent of what ails him.

The biblical account of sin is not pessimism about human nature. It is realism about the human condition — grounded in the seriousness of God's holiness, the clarity of God's law, and the inexorable consequences of the creature's rebellion against its Creator. And it is, paradoxically, the necessary foundation of genuine hope: for only a diagnosis that reaches the true disease can point toward the true cure.

I. The Fall: A Historical Event with Cosmic Consequences

The church has always insisted, on the authority of Scripture and against every allegorical interpretation, that Genesis 3 records a real event in the history of a real man and a real woman — an act of genuine rebellion that had consequences not merely for Adam and Eve but for the entire human race and for the created order itself.

Calvin is emphatic throughout *Institutes* Book II: the fall is not an illustration of a universal human tendency toward self-assertion; it is the originating act from which that tendency flows. Bavinck reinforces this in his *Reformed Dogmatics*: the doctrine of original sin stands or falls with the historicity of the fall. If Adam's sin is merely a symbol, then the human condition has no explanation beyond itself — it is simply what we are, with no alternative account of what we were meant to be or what has gone wrong.

The historical insistence is the theological precondition for the intelligibility of the gospel. Paul's argument in Romans 5:12-21 depends on it: 'just as sin came into the world through one man, and death through sin, and so death spread to all men because all sinned.' The symmetry between Adam and Christ — the one whose disobedience brought condemnation, the one whose obedience brings justification — requires that both be understood as historical heads of the human race whose acts have real consequences for all who are united to them.

II. The Nature of the First Sin

What was the nature of Adam's sin? Faithful teachers of the church since Augustine have consistently identified its deepest root as pride — the refusal to receive the self as a gift from God, the desire to be autonomous, self-defining, self-sufficient. Calvin's analysis is precise: the first sin was not merely an act of disobedience but an act of unbelief — a refusal to trust God's word, a preferring of the creature's own judgment over the Creator's revealed will.

Thomas Watson identifies three dimensions of the first sin. It was an act of ingratitude — committed in the midst of unparalleled blessings. It was an act of pride — the aspiration to be 'like God, knowing good and evil' (Genesis 3:5), the creature's assertion of independence. And it was an act of unbelief — the crediting of the serpent's word over God's word.

Boston's analysis of the spiritual dynamics of the fall is particularly instructive for soul care. The will chose freely — but under the distorting influence of a desire already corrupted by the serpent's suggestion. This is the pattern sin follows in every subsequent temptation: desires are inflamed by a false presentation of the good, judgment is darkened by desire's pressure, and the will chooses what the corrupted affections have made appear desirable. Understanding this sequence is essential for helping anyone trapped in patterns of habitual sin.

The immediate aftermath of Genesis 3 is a portrait every counselor will recognize: shame (they knew they were naked), fear (Adam hides from God), and accusation (Adam blames Eve; Eve blames the serpent). The pattern of deflection and denial that characterizes human responses to conviction begins at the very moment of the first sin.

III. Original Sin: Guilt and Pollution

The consequences of Adam's sin did not remain with Adam alone. By virtue of the solidarity of the human race in its covenant head, his sin is imputed to all his posterity — and with it, the corruption of nature sin produced in him is transmitted to every person born by natural generation. This doctrine of original sin has two distinct components.

Guilt (*reatus*): Every human being is born bearing the legal guilt of Adam's transgression. Paul argues in Romans 5:12-19 that 'by the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners' — not merely affected, not merely influenced, but constituted guilty before God on account of the representative act of the federal head of the race.

Pollution (*corruptio*): Every human being is also born with a corrupted nature — what the Westminster Standards call the corruption of the whole nature, and what Bavinck describes as the thoroughgoing disordering of all the capacities that once bore the image of God in original righteousness. Watson notes pastorally that this inherited pollution is a positive inclination toward evil, not a neutral starting point — as natural as water running downhill. The person who has never understood original sin is often baffled by the intensity of their own sinful desires. The doctrine explains what otherwise appears inexplicable.

IV. Total Depravity: The Extent of Sin's Reach

The biblical doctrine of total depravity does not mean that every person is as sinful as possible, or that no genuine goodness remains in fallen humanity. It means that no dimension of the person has escaped sin's corrupting influence. The fall reached the whole person: mind, will, affections, conscience, and body.

The mind has been darkened. Paul writes in Romans 1:21 that fallen humanity has become futile in their thinking and darkened in their hearts. In 1 Corinthians 2:14, the natural person cannot accept the things of the Spirit because they are spiritually discerned. Calvin is careful here: the mind retains remarkable capacities for the things of this world — arts, sciences, philosophy. These are gifts of common grace. But in the things of God the mind is radically disabled: it needs not more information but illumination, a supernatural work of the Spirit.

The will has been enslaved. The fallen will is not neutral between good and evil. John 8:34: 'everyone who practices sin is a slave to sin.' The will chooses freely — but freely according to its now-corrupted nature. Bavinck notes that genuine freedom was always found in conformity with the divine will; sin has inverted this so that what feels like freedom is actually bondage, and what the gospel calls freedom feels, at first, like constraint.

The affections have been disordered. The loves of the fallen person are inverted: the things that should be most loved are feared or despised, while the things that should be properly subordinated are elevated to the place of supreme devotion. Romans 1:25: they 'worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator.' John Owen's analysis in *Of Indwelling Sin* shows this disorder as an active, deceptive principle — not mere weakness but a persistent force that exploits every

faculty it has corrupted in order to produce sin.

V. The Noetic Effects of Sin: Why Self-Knowledge Is Unreliable

One of the most practically important implications of total depravity for biblical counseling is the unreliability of fallen self-knowledge. The person who comes seeking help has a version of his own story — a narrative about who he is, why he does what he does, and what he needs. This narrative is the place the counselor must begin. But it is not reliable.

Jeremiah 17:9 states it with stark economy: 'The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick; who can understand it?' The heart that is the seat of human identity and motivation is the very thing most corrupted by sin — and not a reliable guide to its own condition. Calvin observes that it is precisely the persons most deeply entangled in sin who are often most confident of their own righteousness. The Pharisee's prayer in Luke 18 is a portrait of fallen self-knowledge at full development: a person whose self-image is so carefully curated that he genuinely cannot see his own sin.

Bavinck connects this to his broader epistemological analysis: the person who does not know God cannot know himself, because the self is only legible in relation to the Creator whose image it bears. Self-knowledge and the knowledge of God are inseparable — the fall damages both simultaneously. This means biblical counseling cannot simply accept the counselee's own account as accurate. The Word of God — which alone penetrates to the division of soul and spirit (Hebrews 4:12) — is the only instrument capable of cutting through the layers of self-deception that sin has built.

VI. The Deceitfulness of Sin

Owen, in *Of Indwelling Sin*, provides the most penetrating Puritan analysis of sin's capacity to hide itself. He identifies several specific mechanisms: sin inflames the imagination and the affections before the judgment can evaluate clearly; it minimizes the seriousness of the proposed transgression, suggesting the sin is small and the consequences unlikely; it presents delay as a reasonable alternative to repentance; and it exploits the person's genuine spiritual concerns, turning even godly instincts into cover for continued disobedience.

For the biblical counselor, Owen's analysis identifies one of the most persistent challenges of the counseling relationship: the person who comes for help has typically not arrived at clear-eyed honesty about his own condition. He has a set of explanations, framings, and justifications that protect him from the full weight of what his actions have meant. The work of biblical counsel is to bring the light of God's Word to bear with patience, precision, and compassion — trusting that the Spirit will do what only he can do.

VII. The Fracture of Relationships

Sin is not only an interior catastrophe — it is a relational one. The image of God is relational all the way down: the person was made for God and for others. Sin disrupts both relationships.

The primary fracture is with God. Romans 5:10 speaks of the unregenerate as enemies of God — not merely indifferent but positively aligned against him. Colossians 1:21 describes the Gentile world as alienated and hostile in mind. This is the actual spiritual condition of every person before regeneration: a posture of opposition to God that may be expressed in active hostility, in apathetic indifference, or in the subtler form of religious self-sufficiency, but that in each case represents a fundamental refusal of the relationship for which the person was made.

The secondary fracture is with the neighbor. The person who does not properly love God cannot properly love his neighbor, because the neighbor is only fully lovable when seen as a fellow image-bearer of the God who commands love. Genesis 3 enacts this with tragic economy: before the fall, Adam and Eve are together in openness and trust; after the fall, they are clothed, afraid, and accusing one another. The first crime after the fall is fratricide. The pattern from garden to city is one of progressive relational disintegration. For the counselor, this means presenting problems are rarely merely private — the person trapped in habitual sin is almost certainly also leaving a trail of relational damage.

VIII. What Remains: Common Grace and the Lingering Image

Total depravity does not require the conclusion that nothing good remains in fallen humanity. Calvin's treatment of common grace in *Institutes* II.2-3 is among the most generous in the history of the church: the intellectual, artistic, and civic achievements of fallen humanity are genuine goods, gifts of the Spirit that should be received with gratitude. He insists that to despise them as worthless because they come from unregenerate persons would be to insult the Spirit who gave them.

But Calvin is equally careful to distinguish common grace from saving grace. The gifts common grace preserves — the structural capacities of the broader image — do not constitute a foothold for salvation. They are God's merciful restraint on the full expression of sin's destructive power. Watson calls what remains the ruins of a palace: not the palace itself, but enough of the structure to indicate what the building was meant to be. Biblical counseling works with what remains — not as though it were sufficient, but as the ground on which the Word of God can land and find response.

IX. Implications for Soul Care: The Diagnosis Must Be Deep Enough

The doctrine of the fall has direct and unavoidable implications for anyone engaged in the care of souls.

The problem is theological before it is psychological. Whatever presenting concern a person brings — anxiety, addiction, relational conflict, sexual sin, guilt, depression — its deepest root is in the disruption of the relationship with God that sin introduced. A counseling approach that addresses the presenting concern without reaching this root has not addressed the real problem, however skillful its handling of the surface issues.

Genuine change requires more than information. The spiritually dead person cannot receive the things of God. The enslaved will cannot free itself. The darkened mind cannot illuminate itself. This means the counselor is not the agent of genuine change — the Holy Spirit is. The counselor's work is to be a faithful instrument through whom the Spirit applies the Word. This is not passivity; it is precision about what human agency can and cannot accomplish.

Empathy must be joined to truth. Richard Sibbes writes of Christ's tenderness toward the bruised reed — and the bruised reed is not a person who has never sinned but one who has sinned deeply and is now broken under the weight of it. The counselor who has truly internalized the doctrine of total depravity is not hard and unmoved by the counselee's pain. He is compassionate, understanding that the person before him is in the grip of something far stronger than his own will. The gentleness of Christ is proportional to the depth of the condition he came to heal.

The gospel must be the destination. Every session that reaches the true depth of a person's condition arrives at the same point: the need for something the person cannot supply for himself. Sin's disruption of the image cannot be addressed by human wisdom, therapeutic technique, or moral exhortation alone. It can only be addressed by the power of the gospel, applied by the Holy Spirit, through the Word of God. This is the direction toward which all faithful soul care must ultimately point.

X. Conclusion: The Catastrophe and the Cure

> *'For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.' (Romans 3:23)*

The magnitude of the fall is measured by the magnitude of what was lost. Part One showed us a creature made in the image of God, crowned with glory, equipped with original righteousness, and oriented toward his Creator and his neighbor. Part Two has shown us what happened to that creature — the image defaced, the righteousness lost, the mind darkened, the will enslaved, the affections disordered, the relationships shattered.

This is not a small problem. It is not a problem that education, therapy, or self-improvement can solve. It requires an intervention from outside — from beyond the fallen order, from the One who made the creature and who alone has the power and the love to restore what sin has destroyed.

Part Three, *God Is Man's World*, first goes back to the garden to hear the word Adam and Eve refused. Then Part Four takes up the restoration itself: *Renewed After the Image* — what redemption and sanctification accomplish in the person, and what the final renewal of the image in Christ looks like. The wound at the root is real and deep. But the Physician who comes to heal it is greater than the wound — and he leaves no case unfinished.

Version 1.1 — Part Two of Four: What It Means to Be Human

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